

A FREE SELF-CHECK FROM SENIOR HOME SAFETY

The home safety checklist.

Fifty-nine things to look at, room by room, in the home of someone you are worried about. Most take a minute. Several cost nothing to put right.

Print it, walk the house with a pen, and tick what is already true. Whatever is left unticked is your list.

Senior Home Safety · Calgary and surrounding area
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BEFORE YOU START

How to use this.

Walk the house with this in your hand and a pen. Tick anything that is already true. Do not tick something because it is nearly true — a grab bar held on by suction cups is not a grab bar.

When you reach the end, the unticked lines are your list. Start with the bathroom and the stairs: that is where the serious falls happen, and most of what is on those two lists is inexpensive.

What this is, and what it is not.

This is a free self-check, not an assessment. It asks whether something is present. A full assessment measures it, prices the fix, ranks it against everything else in the home and names the trade each fix needs. This checklist offers no medical or clinical opinion about anyone, and it is not a home inspection.

01 ENTRANCES & OUTSIDE

Getting in and out

Start outside. Winter in Calgary turns a workable entrance into a hazard for five months of the year.

- ☐ Every exterior step is the same height, with no cracked or loose treads
- ☐ A handrail runs the full length of every set of outside steps
- ☐ The landing at the door is deep enough to stand on while opening the door
- ☐ The path and steps drain away from the house, and do not ice over in the same spot each winter
- ☐ A light at the door switches on before you reach it, or is easy to reach on arrival
- ☐ House numbers are readable from the street, at night, by an ambulance crew
- ☐ The threshold at the door can be crossed without lifting a foot high

02 BATHROOM

The highest-risk room in most homes

More serious falls happen here than anywhere else. Almost everything on this list is cheap to fix.

- ☐ A grab bar is fitted beside the toilet, fixed into studs or backing — not a suction bar
- ☐ A grab bar is fitted at the tub or shower entry, and a second one inside
- ☐ The towel rail is not being used as a grab bar
- ☐ A non-slip mat or strips are fixed in the tub or shower base
- ☐ The bath mat outside the tub has a rubber backing and does not slide
- ☐ The toilet is a comfortable height to stand up from without pulling on anything
- ☐ The floor is not slippery when wet
- ☐ A nightlight or motion light covers the route from the bedroom to the bathroom
- ☐ The door opens outward, or can be unlocked from outside in an emergency

03 STAIRS & HALLWAYS

Every level change in the house

- ☐ A handrail runs the full length of every staircase, top step to bottom step
- ☐ Ideally there is a rail on both sides
- ☐ Every step is the same height and depth — no odd step at the top or bottom
- ☐ The edge of each step is easy to see, by contrast or a strip
- ☐ A light switch sits at both the top and the bottom of the stairs
- ☐ Nothing is stored on the stairs, not even temporarily
- ☐ Hallways are clear enough to pass through carrying something in both hands
- ☐ Carpet on the stairs is firmly fixed with no lifted or worn edges

04 FLOORS & TRIP HAZARDS

What is underfoot

Loose rugs are the single most common finding, and removing one costs nothing.

- ☐ No loose or curled rugs anywhere on a walking route
- ☐ Any rug that stays is taped down or has a non-slip underlay

- ☐ No electrical cords or phone cords cross a walking route
- ☐ Thresholds between rooms are flush, or low enough not to catch a toe
- ☐ No pet bowls, baskets or boxes sit in a walking route
- ☐ Floor surfaces do not change abruptly from grippy to slippery

05 LIGHTING

Being able to see the hazard

Eyes at 75 need roughly three times the light they needed at 40.

- ☐ Every room has enough light to read a medicine label without leaning in
- ☐ No room has to be crossed in the dark to reach its light switch
- ☐ Nightlights cover the bedroom, hallway and bathroom route
- ☐ Burnt-out bulbs are replaced promptly, including ones that need a ladder
- ☐ Nobody is standing on a chair to change a bulb

06 KITCHEN

Reaching, lifting and the stove

- ☐ Everyday items are between waist and shoulder height — no stooping, no reaching up
- ☐ No step stool or chair is being used to reach a shelf
- ☐ The stove has an automatic shut-off, or one could be fitted
- ☐ A working fire extinguisher is within reach of the kitchen, and someone knows how to use it
- ☐ Nothing flammable is stored above or beside the stove
- ☐ Spills on the floor get cleaned up straight away

07 BEDROOM

Where the night-time falls happen

- ☐ The bed is a height where feet reach the floor before standing
- ☐ A lamp or switch can be reached from the bed without getting up

- ☐ A phone can be reached from the bed
- ☐ The route from bed to door is clear and lit
- ☐ Nothing is stored under the bed that gets reached for

08 FIRE, ALARMS & EMERGENCIES

When something goes wrong

- ☐ Working smoke alarms on every level, tested in the last six months
- ☐ A carbon monoxide alarm if there is gas, a fireplace or an attached garage
- ☐ The alarm is loud enough to wake the person, and they know what it means
- ☐ There is a way to call for help from the floor — a worn alarm, or a phone kept low
- ☐ Emergency contacts are written somewhere visible, not only in a phone
- ☐ Two ways out of the house, both usable without a key from inside

09 IF MEMORY IS CHANGING

Additional checks where dementia is a factor

Only relevant for some households. Worth reading even if it does not apply yet.

- ☐ Exterior doors can be secured against leaving unnoticed, but still opened in a fire
- ☐ A door chime or alarm signals when an exterior door opens at night
- ☐ The stove can be isolated or has an automatic shut-off
- ☐ Medication is stored where a second dose cannot be taken by accident
- ☐ The toilet contrasts with the floor and wall, so it can be found easily
- ☐ Mirrors are covered or removed if they cause distress
- ☐ Nothing harmful is stored in a container that looks like food or drink

WHAT NEXT

If the list came out long.

A long list is normal and it is not a verdict on anyone. Most homes were built for whoever lived there at the time, and bodies change faster than houses do.

Work in the order the rooms appear here. Bathroom and stairs first, then floors and lighting. Nearly everything in those four sections is a weekend and a few hundred dollars at most.

If you want the measured version — every finding photographed, measured, priced and ranked, with a phased plan and a checklist for hiring any contractor — that is what we do. Assessments start at \$395 plus GST, and the written report arrives within three business days.

Talk it through first, at no charge.

Call 587-907-3566 or email info@novoseniorsafety.com. We will call back within one business day, and we will say plainly if an assessment would not help you.

Senior Home Safety is a trade name of Novo Industries Inc., Calgary, Alberta. Assessments are carried out by Carl Christie, Senior Home Safety Specialist (SHSS) and RHFAC Professional. This checklist is general information, not advice about any particular home or person.